Neil Hilborn Collection

By Neil Hilborn

INTRODUCTION

Neil Hilborn was diagnosed with Obsessive Compulsive Disorder (OCD) at the age of 11 and with Bipolar Disorder in college. Anxiety and depression have been a part of his life for years. Now he's one of the most-watched spoken word poets in the world – and an accomplished author. And though his work, we find insight into the reality of what it's like to live with mental illness. OCD, The Future and Joey by Neil Hilborn.

OCD

The first time I saw her...

Everything in my head went quiet.

All the tics just disappeared.

When you have Obsessive Compulsive Disorder, you don't really get quiet moments.

Did I lock the doors? Yes.

Did I wash my hands? Yes.

Did I lock the doors? Yes.

Did I wash my hands? Yes.

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But when I saw her,

I knew I had to talk to her.

I asked her out six times in thirty seconds.

On our first date, I spent more time organizing my meal by color than I did eating it...

But she loved it.

She loved that I had to kiss her goodbye sixteen times or twenty-four times if it was Wednesday.

She loved that it took me forever to walk home because there are lots of cracks on our sidewalk.

When we moved in together, she said she felt safe, like no one would ever rob us because I definitely locked the door eighteen times.

I'd always watch her mouth when she talked—

when she talked—

when she talked—

when she talked

when she talked;

when she said she loved me, her mouth would curl up at the edges.

[THEN . . .]

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Some mornings I'd start kissing her goodbye but she'd
just leave cause I was
just making her late for work...
When I stopped in front of a crack in the sidewalk, she
just kept walking...
When she said she loved me her mouth was a straight
line.
She told me that I was taking up too much of her time.
Last week she started sleeping at her mother's place.
She told me that she shouldn't have let me get so
attached to her; that this whole thing was a mistake,
but...
How can it be a mistake that I don't have to wash my
hands after I touch her?
Love is not a mistake, and it's killing me that she can run
away from this and I just can't.
I can't –
I can't –
I can't –

SOURCE INFORMATION

4NG Fanatics

Author: Neil Hilborn
Book: Our Numbered Days
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Date (Month/Year): April 2015

The Future

The worst thing about being naked—and then
being hit by a car—is that road rash
is a problem for skin. Why was I naked
in the middle of the road at noon? I am glad
you asked, imaginary other half of this
conversation! I have no idea! Some characteristics
of bipolar disorder include dissociation, hallucinations,
and fugue states, so sometimes I wake up in places
I didn't go to sleep!
So. There I am. Nude. Splayed out on a car, and I'm
screaming about the government
conspiracy to take away my feet.
"This is not how I imagined my life would turn out."
When I was young, I broke
both my ankles jumping off a roof because
I was sure a cape would enable me to fly. My parents

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attributed this to my strong imagination. Last year,
my therapist called it a delusion. I fail
to see the difference. Also, I really can fly and see the
future – 43% of the time.
They keep telling me seeing things that aren't
technically there
is called "disturbed cognitive functioning." I call it
"having a superpower."
Once, I pulled over on the 110 freeway
and jumped out of my old Jeep because I saw it burst
into flames twenty seconds before it actually burst
into flames. I know tomorrow is going to come
because I've seen it. Sunrise is going to come,
all you have to do is wake up. The future
looks like a child in a cape. The future looks just like
gravity: everyone is slowly drifting toward everyone
else.
I saw the future, I did,
and in it I was alive.

SOURCE INFORMATION

4NG Fanatics

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Book: The Future
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Joey

Joey always told me, laughing, as though it were actually
a joke
That he wanted to kill himself but it was never the right
time,
There were always groceries to be bought
And little brothers to be tucked in at night.
Don't worry, Joey isn't gonna kill himself 20 more
seconds into this poem,
It's not that kind of story I'm telling here.

I once caught Joey in my dad's office,
Staring at the safe where he knew we kept the guns
Once Joey molded his car into the shape of a tree trunk
and refused to give a reason why
I once caught Joey in biology class
Staring at a scalpel like he wanted to be the frog

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Splayed out, wide open
So honest

There is one difference between me and Joey:
When we got arrested, bail money was waiting for me at the station
When I was hungry, I ate
When I wanted to open myself up and see if there really were bees rattling around in there,
My parents got me a therapist.
I can pinpoint the session that brought me back to the world,
That session cost seventy-five dollars.
Seventy-five dollars is two weeks of groceries
It's a month of bus fare
It took weeks of seventy-five dollars to get to the one that saved my life.
We both had parents that believed us when we said that we weren't okay
But mine could afford to do something about it

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I wonder how many kids like Joey wanted to die,
And were unlucky enough to actually pull it off,
How many kids had people who cared about them but also had to pay rent?
I'm so lucky that right now I'm not describing Joey's funeral
I'm so lucky we all lived through who we were
To become who we are
I'm so lucky-
I'm so
Lucky

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier